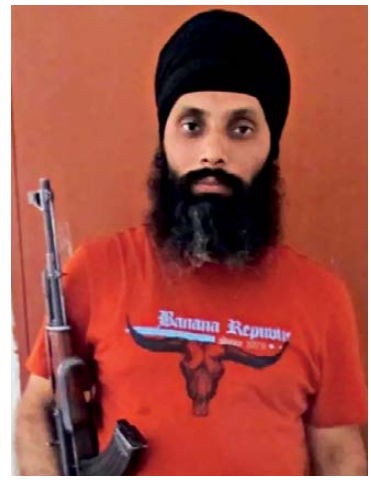




OUTGUNNED
Nijjar bearing arms; a poster declaring him a martyr



AFP

BY 2018, CANADA HAD PUT NIJJAR'S NAME ON THE NO-FLY LIST AND THE FOLLOWING YEAR, THE US TOO DID THE SAME

Khalistani militants in Thailand in 2007 to form a 'global module'. Members of this module were reportedly involved in the bomb blast at Ludhiana's Shingar Cinema the same year and the killing of Rulda Singh, a leader of the Rashtriya Sikh Sangat, an RSS affiliate, in 2009.

Nijjar returned on the Punjab Police radar around 2013-14, when he joined the KTF after Jagtar Singh Tara became the self-styled leader of the terror outfit (police reports suggest the two met first at the 2007 Thailand rendezvous). But from then on, Nijjar seems to have gone on overdrive. Indian security agencies believe he visited Pakistan a number of times during this period to coordinate pro-Khalistan activities.

The year 2015 was momentous for Nijjar. After Tara was arrested from Bangkok—he had been convicted in the 1995 bomb blast killing of then Punjab chief minister Beant Singh—Nijjar became the new KTF chief. The KTF headquarters, too, shifted to Surrey. But during interrogation, Tara reportedly spilled the beans about Nijjar's plan to transport guns across the Indo-Pak border into Amritsar using a paraglider. The plan was foiled and security agencies were soon requesting the Royal Canadian Mounted Police (RCMP), the national police service there, to track Nijjar's whereabouts.

In 2016, the new KTF chief reportedly enlisted gangsters to carry out targeted killings in Punjab, including that of RSS leader Jagdish Gagneja in Jalandhar. Earlier, in December 2015, Nijjar reportedly organised arms training camps for 'apprentice terrorists' in the rural Mission Hills area of British Columbia. This was revealed after the Punjab Police arrested one of them, Mandeep Singh Dhaliwal, in June 2016. He had reportedly been sent by Nijjar to India with a hit list. The targets included ex-Punjab top cop Mohammad Izhar Alam and Sikh religious leader Baba Mann Singhji Pehowa. A red corner notice was soon issued against Nijjar.

By 2018, Canada had put Nijjar's name on the no-fly list and the following year, the US too did same, after a recommendation by the Federal Bureau of Investigation. In 2020, the National Investigation Agency (NIA) declared Nijjar a terrorist and confiscated his properties in India. The agencies also alleged that his men had infiltrated the farmers' union protests in 2020-21.

The year 2023, of course, has proved ruinous for Nijjar and many other pro-Khalistan outfit leaders. Nijjar's name cropped up again in the controversial case of pro-Khalistan propagandist Amritpal Singh who was arrested in April. Then, in May, unidentified assailants killed Khalistan Commando force chief and veteran militant Paramjit Panjwar in Lahore. On June 15, Khalistan Liberation Force (KLF) chief Avtar Khanda, a cancer patient, died at a hospital in London. A week later, Nijjar, too, met his end.

—Anilesh S. Mahajan